Daily Science Anecdotes

Topic: Could Your Brain Invent a Person?

by Zainab Salami October 13, 2026

There is a specific, reproducible way to make someone feel an unseen presence is nearby, and it does not require darkness, isolation, or fear. It requires a machine that has never been near a brain: a robot.

In 2014, researchers at the Swiss Federal Institute of Technology in Lausanne built a robotic setup that let blindfolded participants move a stick with one hand, while a robotic arm behind them touched their back with a slight, deliberately built-in delay matched to their own movement. With the delay in place, several participants reported something no one told them to expect: the unmistakable feeling that **someone else was in the room with them, standing just behind their shoulder.** Some found it so disturbing they asked to stop the experiment. No one else was present. The only thing behind them was a mechanical arm and a fraction of a second of mistimed touch.

The explanation traces back to how your brain builds a model of your own body in space, using a constant stream of signals from your muscles, joints, and inner ear, cross-checked against what you feel touching your skin. Ordinarily, when you move your own hand and feel a delayed echo of that motion on your back, your brain correctly attributes it to you. Introduce a strange enough delay, and that self-monitoring system starts to misfire: it registers a body-shaped signal it cannot match to your own movement, and rather than concluding the sensor is malfunctioning, it produces the far more intuitive interpretation that someone else must be generating it.

This same failure mode shows up outside the laboratory under very different conditions. Mountaineers at extreme altitude and long-distance solo sailors have independently reported an invisible companion during periods of exhaustion, cold, and oxygen deprivation, conditions that place unusual strain on exactly the same body-monitoring networks. Polar explorer Ernest Shackleton described the same experience during his 1916 crossing of South Georgia, and it later lent its name to what climbers now call the **"Third Man" phenomenon**. What a robotic arm can trigger in a lab in fifteen minutes, extreme physical stress can apparently trigger on a mountainside in a matter of days.

The unifying idea is that your sense of "self" is not a fixed fact your brain simply knows. It is a live construction, rebuilt continuously from incomplete sensory data, and under the right conditions, whether mechanical, physiological, or purely a matter of exhaustion, that construction can fracture into what feels unmistakably like two.

So if a robotic arm and a fraction of a second of delay is enough to conjure a person standing behind you, how sure are you that the one sense you never doubt, the sense of yourself, is really unified at all?